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Jan 24 - Jan 30

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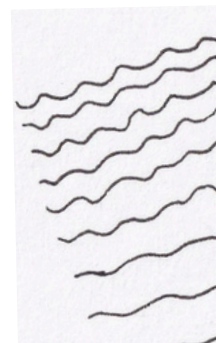
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note from the editor

It didn't make it in time. The package I've been waiting for all day, it's still not here. Every few minutes I pop my head out the door, turn my face this way and that, and every time, emptiness.

The new home I planned to build for my beloved pet cat won't make it in time. I'll have to send this off to print now. . .



Stacker.news is a rewarding pay-to-post pro bitcoin app where you'll find interesting discussion on almost anything. (and if you don't see it, you bring it.)

Stacker News Zine chronicles the activities of cyber cowboys who tend to sling sats for their mortal thoughts

Bitcoin Meetups [New Hampshire/Massachusetts]

top boost

482 sats \ 1112 boost \ 0 comments \ @NEEDcreations 29 Jan bitcoin events



You can find all the NH and MA Bitcoin meetups posted to this group on Meetup

<https://www.meetup.com/massachusetts-bitcoin-meetup/>



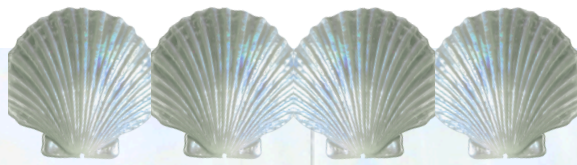
The next NH meetup is coming up on February 20. It's listed on Meetup and also posted on Club Orange events with details here:

<https://app.cluborange.org/xPkBtZbl>



Please let your friends know who are in the New England area!

top
post



Trip Report: Isla Mujeres

14.9k sats \ 21 comments \ @leo 26 Jan Travel

Isla Mujeres, the “Island of Women”, is a small narrow island in the Caribbean, just outside of Cancun. It’s fairly easy to get to using buses and a ferry from Cancun airport, which is well connected with the entire world. The island is lovely and in my opinion strongly preferable over the ritzy resorts of Playa del Carmen. It’s easy to get around by foot or bike, or as the elderly tourists do, by golf cart. Beyond [BTCMaps](#) I used [BTC Isla Map](#) to find businesses that accept sats.

The island is very touristy and suffers from the same logistical problems as most other parts of Mexico: Tourists no longer bring cash with them. Credit card processing fees are usually passed on to the consumer, so there often is a 3-5% surcharge on the bill when paying with card. On top of that, you will typically get hit with the “foreign exchange rate scam,” where the payment terminal will prompt you to pay in the currency of your card, instead of pesos. This will cost you an additional 10% in fees, some of it seems to go to the merchants, as they love that feature and will often confirm this for you on the screen if you don’t pay close enough attention. Getting cash is expensive too, there is a 5% fee for exchanging USD at a forex broker, and higher for other currencies. Withdrawing cash from a bank ATM isn’t always straight forward as there aren’t many, they may be empty or out of service, and there is typically a US\$10-20 flat fee.

It is no surprise that Bitcoin payments are taking hold on the island. The Bitcoin Isla project is spearheaded by Isabella Santons ([Stacker News AMA here](#)). Together with Claudio she runs Mayakita, a nice hotel in the middle of the island, right by the coast.

🚕 There’s a taxi dispatch service on the island that takes Bitcoin. You can message +529981038449 on Whatsapp and fetch a ride, typically for about 150-200 pesos. I myself only took one taxi during my time there, precisely to try it out, but my driver did not accept Bitcoin even after I specified that I wanted to pay over Lightning at the dispatch. But I do know it works because I meet other people who succeed.

🏠 At Mayakita there is a small restaurant with a bar and rooftop cafe, a few single rooms and villas with living rooms, kitchens and multiple bedrooms. There are rooftops with great views over the ocean, tubs and a small swimming pool. It’s all

very inviting and I’m enjoying my stay. On my first day, I decide to have lunch around the area, because I see a few places around me on the map, but some of them might not exist, and others aren’t open. So I have lunch at Mayakita. There are Bitcoin signs and stickers all around, and the staff are wearing Bitcoin-themed uniforms. I order the Shrimp Ceviche and a coke, which comes to a total of about US\$26. More expensive than back home, but we are on a remote island, afterall. I ask to pay with Bitcoin and am directed to the counter, where I’m shown my bill. It includes some suggested tipping amounts. I choose the lowest, but then the cashier enters the original amount into the Coinos web app and selects the 10% tipping option. Coinos has been difficult for me to reach recently, with Lightning Network fees up to 0.5% percent. In this payment I pay 0.3% in fees, which I find quite high.



🛒 There’s a small convenience store nearby. I want to get a bottle of water, and I ask to pay with Bitcoin. The cashier asks the manager, who directs them to an app on their phone that I don’t recognize. She shows me an onchain address, but we cannot find Lightning in the app. We give up and I leave the store without buying anything.

🕒 I have breakfast at Bistro Isla. The manager is quite chatty and tells me right away he doesn’t accept Bitcoin, only the owner does. He finds it too difficult and he doesn’t see the point. Card processing fees don’t seem to bother him, and he doesn’t charge a premium over cash payments. He tells of an English couple that came the day before that was also disappointed he didn’t accept Bitcoin. He says that if he had a dedicated Bitcoin POS, he would accept it, because it is easy, but he doesn’t like to navigate to some website on his phone.

🏧 There is a “Cryptobox” ATM at the Bitcoin Cafe, and another one at Bistro Isla. At first I fail to use either because the verification SMS never arrive, but eventually I ask a local for help, and I am able to “invest” in Mexican pesos. The delivery of the one-time code might be smoother if you use a phone number associated with a WhatsApp account, and have the message sent to the app instead. With only the phone number as verification, I can only withdraw either 500 or 1000 pesos. (US\$29-58). I assume there are some limits on how many times per day or week I can use the machine, but I do not find out. For comparison, at the ferry pier you can exchange up to US\$980 at a time without showing ID. The ATM accepts Lightning payments, which of course I make use of. The rate is quite competitive, I calculate a 3.2% fee on top of the mid-market exchange rate. That’s a better rate than at the fiat ATM or the currency changers. An American or Canadian tourist would definitely be better off using this machine with their Cash App/Strike/Shakepay Account over other methods. It takes my node over a minute to find a route to the destination, as the recipient node is difficult to reach and “hidden” behind Kraken, which themselves is hard to reach. I pay 0.32% in Lightning routing fees, which seems unnecessarily high.

top
post

continued 🍊 Mini Super Go is a small and welcoming little store by the main road towards the middle of the island. I ask to pay with Bitcoin and the owner happily says yes. He localizes his Bitcoin POS under the counter, but the battery seems empty. Even after plugging the charger in, he cannot get it to work, so he opens his phone instead and gives me an invoice through Wallet of Satoshi. He says that only one person ever pays with Bitcoin, la "Bitcoin chica." As I come back another time a different person is behind the counter. The PoS terminal is charged now but she doesn't know which app to select. I can see a few familiar logos on the screen but don't say anything. She goes to the back room and comes back giving me an invoice through Wallet of Satoshi, and I show her the 'Point of Sale' feature of the app in the hope that it feels easier and more professional in the future.

🍷 The town at the northern end of the island is the lively part of town. This is the most walkable and convenient part of Isla Mujeres. On the eastern shore, which is always windy, is a beautiful walk right along the water. Here I find Tiny Gecko, a pub with cheesy live music. I buy a beer and ask to pay with Bitcoin, and the manager immediately agrees. I get him to download Wallet of Satoshi and pay for my drink, plus a "welcome to Bitcoin tip." As I return for another beer later I am told that the owner of the place does not want to accept Bitcoin payments, as he doesn't know how to convert it.

🌮 Tacos Toro is a street food cart near the center of town. They specialize in Tacos, and as I ask to pay with Bitcoin the owner pulls out Blink and gives me an invoice over the amount. No questions, no extra fees, no prompts for tips, a great experience. The taco itself is good, too.

🍒 Right next to the taco stand is a neat little place to get dessert. You can get Marquesitas, sweet pancakes, and Churros, deep fried dough sticks. The manager uses Blink to collect my payment, which goes through promptly.

☕ Neko Coffee is on the far northern side of the main town. They also make fresh sandwiches and have a wide variety of coffee. There's a large Bitcoin sign by the counter, giving me confidence my sats will be accepted, but when it comes to paying the server apologizes and says it's currently unavailable. I excuse myself and am about to ride off as the manager arrives, ready to take my payment through Blink wallet.

🍔 Isla Burger is affiliated with Bistro Isla, where I didn't have any luck with Bitcoin payments. But here everything goes smoothly. There's a Bitcoin sticker at the door, staff is familiar with the system, and I am able to remind them to charge their Bitcoinize machine ahead of time, because of course it isn't.

🐟 The best meal I had on Isla Mujeres was definitely at Fuego de Mar, not far from the Bitcoin Cafe. As I walk in and ask to pay with Bitcoin I am enthusiastically welcomed. The manager even brings her Bitcoinize machine to show she is prepared.

I order the "catch of the day," a black grouper, baked in almonds. It tastes wonderful. I have a lava cake for dessert and a sangria, all recommendations of the waiter. As it comes to payment, of course the Bitcoinize turns out to be out of battery. Instead the manager pulls out her phone and gives me an invoice, at first denominated in U.S. dollar, not pesos. We change the currency and I get the right invoice, and I notice I am the first one to make a payment to her Wallet of Satoshi account.

Isla Mujeres is easy to get to, especially from large cities in North America. It's definitely worth the trip, especially to hang out at the Bitcoin Cafe and spend some sats around town. The shops could definitely use a few more people spending sats, and that should give them a better deal than exchanging cash or using a credit card. The island seems ripe for Bitcoin adoption, but the pieces are not yet fully in place. People I talked to didn't always know how to use their apps, and were worried about not being able to pay their bills with Bitcoin, or get local currency. I was wondering how many of the American tourists around me had Cash App. It would be advantageous for them too, to pay and withdraw cash over the Lightning Network. But there are no currency changers that swap sats, and no Bitcoin ATMs in the busy part of town. And who will tell them?



View from the Bitcoin cafe



Tacos from Taco Toro



The churros cart

top
post



Can a bitcoin standard improve animal welfare? An analysis

5826 sats \ 13 comments \ @SimpleStacker

28 Jan bitcoin_beginners BooksAndArticles
Politics_And_Law Animal_World

For reasons completely unknown to me, a few weeks ago I developed a very strong desire to research books and articles at the intersection of animal welfare, bitcoin, and politics, but unfortunately I came up with a big fat nada. Oh, I did find a few Facebook posts here and there wondering about whether crypto can help animal rights, and I found a few announcements of animal rights groups accepting cryptocurrency donations, but I didn't really find anything with the gravitas worthy of this endeavor. (For some reason, I felt quite deeply that the task was very grandiose, but I don't know why I felt that way.)

But since I couldn't find anything someone else had written, why not write my own article, I thought? Surely, an endeavor of this importance was worth a few hours of my time?

So, I dove headlong into my quest---researching how bitcoin can be a tool for improving animal welfare, and I came to the following conclusion: **while animal experimentation is unlikely to completely end under a Bitcoin standard, there will probably be less of it, and especially less of it used in projects that have low potential for social value.**

Here is my reasoning.

The Scale of Animal Research

Official USDA statistics report that each year, about 775,000 animals (excluding rats, mice, birds, fish, and cold-blooded animals) are used for research in the United States. The reason that rats, mice, birds, etc. are not included in those statistics is because they are not covered by the Animal Welfare Act (AWA), and therefore experiments using them do not need to be reported at all. Thus,



the true number of animals used in research is actually much higher. Estimates for the total number of animals used for research in the US range from about 25 million to over 100 million. Global estimates are even higher, with one study putting the number used globally at nearly 200 million.

In the US, 240,000 AWA-covered animals are used each year in experiments that result in pain, including over 12,000 dogs and over 3,000 cats. And in 56,000 of those experiments, no attempt was made to minimize the pain. These numbers include only the species covered by the AWA, and thus the total number of animals of all species experiencing pain as the result of scientific experimentation is much higher. And presumably, if we extrapolate to the whole world, where the standards for ethical treatment of animals are much laxer, the numbers are even higher.

Scandalous Examples

Harvard Infant Monkey Experiments

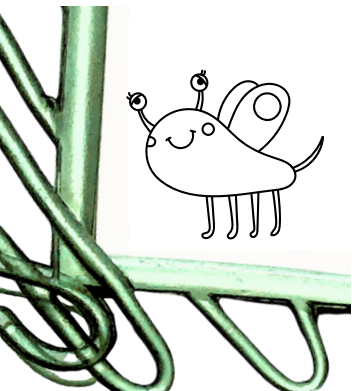
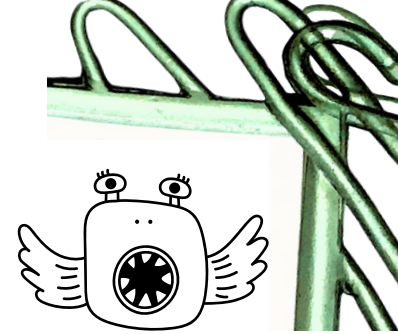
In 2025, under public pressure, Harvard University shut down the lab of Dr. Margaret Livingstone for animal welfare violations. The lab was found to have "tore baby monkeys away from their mothers and deprived them of normal visual input to observe the harmful effects on their developing brains", "forced infant monkeys to wear goggles that simulated disorienting strobe lights for the first 18 months of their lives", and "sewn other monkeys' eyes shut, and after years of torment, killed and dissected many of the animals."

Scientific Beagle Breeding Abuse

Scientific Beagle Breeding Abuse
In 2022, Envigo, a breeder of research dogs(!) in Virginia, was shut down after investigators discovered severe violations of the AWA. An undercover investigation discovered "over 360 puppies lying dead among their littermates", "staff depriving nursing mothers of food", "unqualified workers cutting puppies out of sedated dogs' abdomens before euthanizing the mothers", and "dogs being denied veterinary care and dying after falling into a drain".

NIAID Funded Abuse of Dogs

NIAID Funded Abuse of Dogs
In 2021, controversy erupted when a FOIA request found that the NIAID had been funding multiple drug tests involving puppies, including tests that "involved injecting and force-feeding the puppies an experimental drug for several weeks, before killing and dissecting them." Of particular concern was a line item discovered for a "cordectomy", which is a medical procedure for "slitting a dog's vocal cords in order to prevent them from barking, howling, or crying." One of the projects, which was later fact-checked to be not funded by NIAID, allegedly involved "locking beagles'



continued

heads in mesh cages filled with hundreds of infected sand flies.”
This project led to the following widely circulated image:



Although that particular study was later discovered to not have been funded by NIAID, the other mentioned studies were, and the controversy eventually led to the NIH's last remaining beagle testing lab to be shut down in 2025.

The Economic Argument

Now, don't get me wrong. I'm not some bleeding heart animal rights activist. I'm not signing up for PETA any time soon.

But regardless of your ethical position on animal rights, I think most people can agree: scientific experimentation on animals without proportional benefit is of no merit, and should thus be discouraged.

And so that's the angle I'm coming at it from. By decreasing the availability of government funding for animal studies, we reduce the number of studies for which the benefits are not commensurate with the ethical cost of using animals in experimentation.

Now, you might be wondering: why are privately undertaken studies more likely to have benefits commensurate with the ethical cost of using animals in experimentation? The first step is to acknowledge that there *is* a cost. Even if the company itself does not care, reputational harm is enough for the business to consider the ethical cost of mistreating animals. A private business must carefully balance the potential value of a project with the costs to produce it. If a particular research project is likely to be of low value, a private business would not be willing to risk reputational damage in pursuit of that project.

This accountability is not present in government funded research. The ability to acquire funding for a government-funded project has less to do with the potential market value of the project and more to do with who the researcher knows within the granting agency, or how much the research is aligned with the ideological aims of the bureaucracy. This results in a total disconnect between the potential social value of a project and its ethical implications. This is how we get taxpayer-funded research projects spending millions of dollars to create transgender lab rats.

You might counter that the businesses who were shut down for abusing puppies were private businesses. But that argument misses the fact that their primary customers were most likely government funded research labs. I say "most likely" because there are no statistics about what fraction of animal research is done using public vs. private funds. But nevertheless, we know that a significant fraction (about 47%) of NIH funded research involves animal experimentation. These labs were thus, assuredly, part of the customer base that purchased animals from these abusive breeders, and they are the customers least likely to be worried about reputational damage and least likely to have their incentives aligned towards the potential value of the project.

So how does Bitcoin enter into the picture? Under a Bitcoin standard, governments will be much more tightly constrained in how they can spend their money. Because governments will not be able to print money out of thin air, and because they won't be able to as easily confiscate money from their citizens, even the government will have to be more careful about how it spends its money. In other words, animal research under a Bitcoin standard will only be undertaken for the highest valued projects, because low-valued projects simply wouldn't get funded.

Of course, you may see that as a bit of a utopian dream: can governments really be trusted to make better decisions if only the money were better? I agree that this is perhaps a bit too utopian. As Josh Hendrickson has pointed out, hard money standards have not prevented governments from undertaking stupid actions in the past.



Nevertheless, the symptoms of a fiat driven society are plain as day to us *right now*. Even if Bitcoin does not result in some perfect utopia, as it's unlikely to do, it will still be a step in the right direction---including for animal welfare.

comments

67 sats \ 1 reply \ [@Undisciplined](#) 28 Jan

I'm not Public Choice expert but I think they'd frame your argument slightly differently.

Government actors, lacking profit and loss feedback, do not perceive value in the same way as market entrepreneurs. So, it's not that they'd be better at choosing socially valuable projects under hard money constraints.

I see the benefits coming from these two mechanisms:

1. Most of these unethical research projects are peripheral to the goals of state actors, so they'll prioritize other (probably also unethical) stuff that matters more to them.
2. With near certainty, state activities generate economic losses. Therefore, fewer state activities = reduced losses.

↳ 69 sats \ 0 replies \ [@SimpleStacker](#) OP 28 Jan

This is probably correct.

Though, I think my reasoning works even if the state actors' objectives were aligned with social value. (State actors are more likely to go beyond $MB=MC$, to $MB < MC$)

top
meme

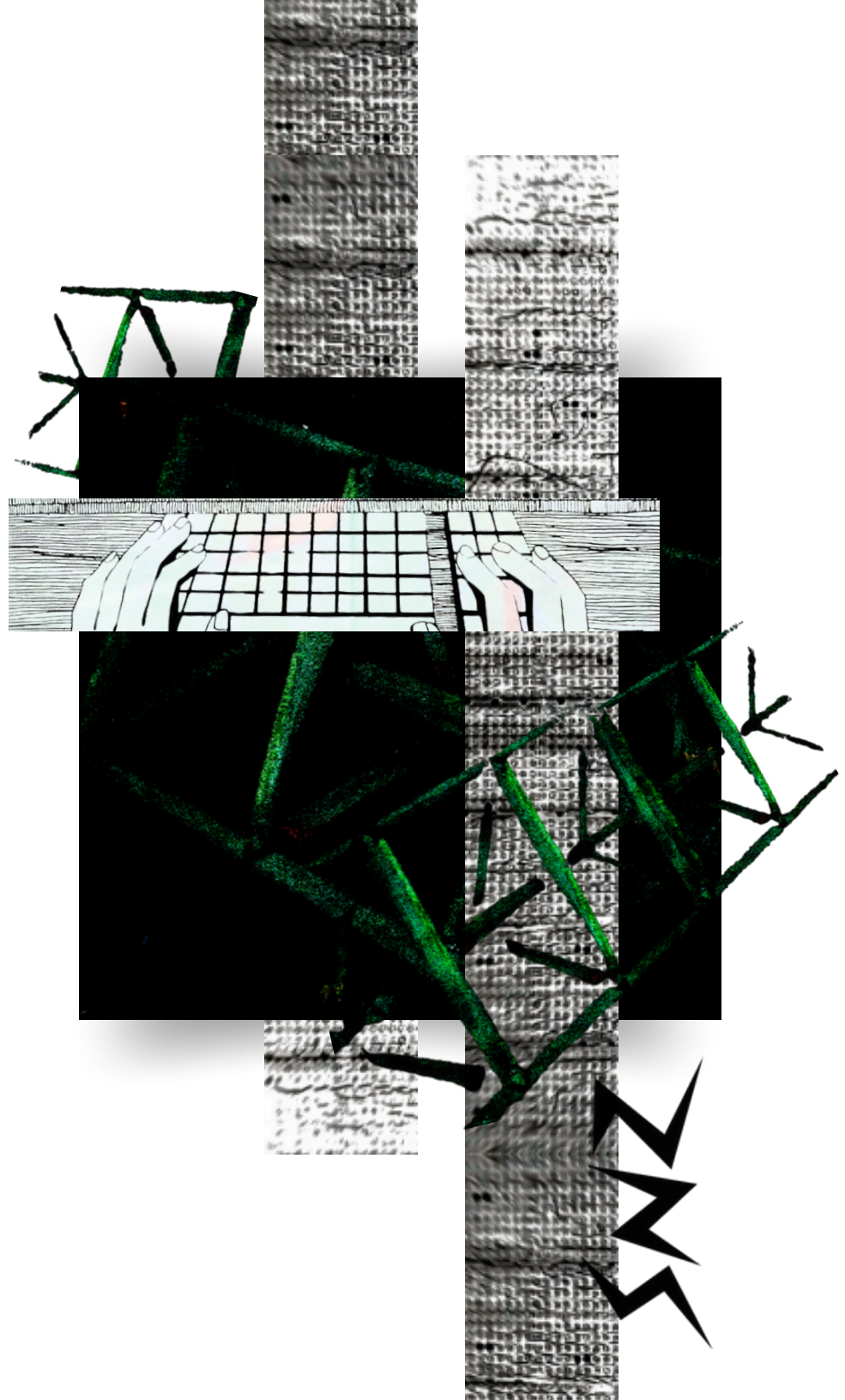
Meme Monday – Top Meme Goes in the Newsletter

362 sats \ 2 comments \ [@sn](#) 26 Jan memes

31 sats \ 0 replies \ [@hasherstacker](#) 26 Jan



90 sats \ 0 replies \ [@DarthCoin](#) 26 Jan



top
post



Ray Dalio's comments on the beginning of our new civil war

3441 sats \ 46 comments \ [@elvismercury](#) 26 Jan mostly_harmless

Over the last few years, Dalio has been an articulate chronicler of macro economic, political, and historical transitions. I own all of the books he's written on these topics, and while I haven't read them all front-to-back, I find his argumentation compelling and the presentation clear. I've sometimes wondered what I'd do if I was rich as fuck, if I could hire a team of lackeys to help me produce great works. Dalio is an interesting example of what someone has done in those circumstances.

As a bitcoiner, I spent years wondering why he didn't find btc worthy of remark in his analysis, given how compatible his framework is with btc's principles and ethos. He'd get right to the edge and then turn away. Of course, in the last year or so he has come around, though not so far as many bitcoiners would like.

Anyway, his most recent post pulls from that extensive body of work. It's sobering.

< *The United States is now a tinderbox. Nearly a third of Americans (30%) say people may have to resort to violence in order to get the country back on track, according to the latest PBS News/NPR/Marist poll. Pew Research Center (Sept-Oct 2025) found that 85% of U.S. adults acknowledged that politically motivated violence is increasing in the U.S.*

If you're been around SN for a while, you know that I'm a pretty moderate voice on this stuff. After Saturday, I've crossed over. I now think widespread and enduring civil violence is likely, and I think it's close. Like weeks-to-months close.

< *A CSIS analysis found that from 2016 to 2024 there were 21 partisan political attacks or plots, compared with only two such incidents in the 25+ years before 2016. That's roughly a tenfold increase in politically-motivated plots/attacks in a relatively short period. There are more guns in the United States than people, and many people have a violent streak in them. Certainly, the conflict between the central government and Minnesota (and other state governments) is bad and looks likely to get worse. The world saw the killings in Minneapolis of two opponents to Trump's ICE initiative and is now watching to see which side will back down.*

TACO used to be a pattern we could count on, but it seems less the case lately. I think the next couple weeks will be telling.

com ments

251 sats \ 1 reply \ [@StillStackinAfterAllTheseYears](#) 26 Jan
I suspect you're right and hope you're wrong. My thinking has gone in the same direction (so I guess I hope I'm wrong, too).

↳ 21 sats \ 0 replies \ [@elvismercury](#) OP 26 Jan
Crossing fingers that we're both wrong.

161 sats \ 5 replies \ [@kepford](#) 26 Jan
Its here and has been off and on for a while. Not cheering it on. On the contrary I have been talking about a civil national divorce for years. Seems neither side will leave the other alone. The reasons differ but it's not one sided. Seems unavoidable now.